JIRA — Complete Study Notes

Course: Understanding Jira for Users, Managers, and Admins | Instructor: Dan Lefebvre

PHASE 1 — THE MENTAL MODEL

1.1 What Is Jira?

Jira is an agile project management and work tracking tool created by Atlassian. The name comes from 'Gojira' — the Japanese name for Godzilla — which was itself derived from 'Bugzilla', a Mozilla bug-tracking tool. Atlassian wanted something more powerful than Bugzilla for tracking bugs and internal work, so they built Jira in-house, and it eventually became the industry-standard tool it is today.

What Jira Is Designed For

Jira is built specifically for agile project management. It assumes your team is using an agile framework. Everything inside Jira — the boards, the backlog, sprints, issue types, workflows — is designed around agile principles. Trying to use Jira with a non-agile framework like Waterfall will feel like swimming upstream.

What Jira Is NOT

- Not a general-purpose project tool — not designed for Waterfall, Six Sigma, or Prince2 by default.
- Not a communication tool — it integrates with Slack and Microsoft Teams but is not one itself.
- Not a documentation tool — that is Confluence, a separate Atlassian product.

⚠ NOTE: Jira's 'projects' do NOT mean the same thing as day-to-day projects. In Jira, a project is a container for work items, not a task list for a specific work goal. This is one of the most common sources of confusion for new users.

1.2 Agile Methodology Overview

Agile is a set of rules and practices that teams use to get work done in a flexible, continuously improving way. Originally developed by software engineers in the early 2000s, it has since been adopted by marketing, customer service, creative, and operations teams worldwide. Its key principles are adaptability, team transparency, and continuous improvement.

The Agile Board

The fundamental visual artifact in agile is the agile board. Work moves from left to right across the board as it progresses. In Jira, the horizontal lanes are called columns (not lanes, which is the broader agile term). A basic board has:

- **Backlog** — all work not yet started or scheduled
- **To Do / Not Started** — work committed for the current sprint

- **In Progress** — work actively being worked on
- **Done** — completed work

1.3 Scrum vs Kanban

Jira supports two core agile frameworks, and each maps to a specific board type. Understanding the difference is essential because your board type determines whether sprints are available and how work flows.

Feature	Scrum	Kanban
Sprints	Yes — time-boxed blocks of work	No — continuous flow
Backlog	Yes — formal backlog with sprint planning	Optional (off by default in Jira)
Daily Standup	Yes	Yes
Planning Meeting	Sprint planning at the start of each sprint	Not formally required
Retrospective	At the end of each sprint	Less formal, ongoing
WIP Limits	Implicit via sprint capacity	Explicit WIP limits on columns
Best For	Predictable work, fixed timelines	Ongoing/continuous work, support teams

⚠ NOTE: Scrum uses Sprints; Kanban does not. This is the single most important difference in Jira. The board type you create determines whether sprints are available.

1.4 The Sprint Lifecycle (Scrum)

A sprint is a fixed block of time — typically one to two weeks — during which the team commits to completing a defined set of work. Sprints give rhythm to the team's work and force prioritization. Here is the complete lifecycle:

Before the Sprint

- Everyone adds work items to the backlog that they believe need to get done.
- Items are estimated (in hours or story points).
- Items are prioritized — highest priority goes to the top.

Sprint Planning Meeting

- The team reviews the previous sprint retrospectively (except the very first sprint).
- What went well, what didn't, and what can improve.
- The team agrees on a sprint length (commonly two weeks).
- Work items are pulled from the backlog into the sprint until capacity is filled.

- Sprint is named, given a goal, and optionally a description with available hours.

⚠ NOTE: A useful tip: include the total available work hours in the sprint goal/description — e.g. '54 hours (9 days due to holiday)'. This makes capacity planning visible to the whole team during the meeting.

Daily Standup

Every morning during the sprint, the team holds a brief (≈15 minute) standup meeting. Each person answers three questions:

- What did you do yesterday?
- What will you do today?
- What roadblocks do you have?

During the Sprint

- Work items move from To Do → In Progress → Done on the board.
- New requests go to the backlog — NOT mid-sprint, except in rare emergencies.
- If something must be added mid-sprint, an item of equal weight should be removed.

End of Sprint

- Retrospective — what went well, what didn't, what to improve.
- Incomplete items are moved to the next sprint or back to the backlog.
- New sprint begins — the cycle repeats.

1.5 Key Jira Terminology

Jira uses specific terms that have precise meanings. Knowing these upfront prevents confusion inside the tool.

Term	Jira's Definition
Project	A container for work items. NOT the same as a work project. Think of it as a folder or workspace.
Work Item (Issue)	Any unit of trackable work — story, task, bug, epic. The term 'issue' is legacy; 'work item' is current.
Issue Key	Unique identifier — project key + number (e.g. WDT-42). Automatically generated.
Epic	A large container of related work items. Epics span multiple sprints. Work items live inside epics.
Story / User Story	A work item written from the user's perspective — 'As a user, I want to...'
Task	A generic unit of work not written as a user story.
Bug	A defect or error in the product.

Term	Jira's Definition
Subtask	A child work item under a parent story or task.
Sprint	A time-boxed period (1-4 weeks) of focused work. Scrum only.
Backlog	The queue of all work items not yet in a sprint.
Status	The current state of a work item (e.g. To Do, In Progress, Done).
Workflow	The defined sequence of statuses and transitions a work item moves through.
Transition	Moving a work item from one status to another.
Field	A data attribute on a work item — summary, assignee, priority, labels, story points, etc.
Board	The visual Kanban or Scrum board showing work item cards in columns.
Filter	A saved JQL search query. Boards are powered by filters.
JQL	Jira Query Language — the query language used to search and filter work items.
Component	A sub-area or category within a project. Per-project (not global).
Version / Release	A named grouping of work items associated with a product release.
Resolution	A label explaining how/why a work item was moved to Done.
Dashboard	A customizable page of widgets/gadgets showing project information.
Scheme	A reusable configuration that is applied to one or more projects.

Phase 1 — Summary Reference

Concept	Key Point
Jira origin	Gojira → Godzilla. Built by Atlassian to replace Bugzilla.
Jira's purpose	Agile project management and work tracking only.
Agile board	Columns: Backlog → To Do → In Progress → Done
Scrum	Has sprints. Time-boxed. Sprint planning + retrospective.
Kanban	No sprints. Continuous flow. Optional backlog.
Sprint	Fixed time block (usually 2 weeks). Everyone fills it to capacity.
Standup	Daily 15-min meeting. 3 questions: yesterday / today / blockers.
Project in Jira	A container for work items — NOT a work task.
Issue key	Auto-generated: PROJECT_KEY + number (e.g. WDT-1)

PHASE 2 — CORE BUILDING BLOCKS

2.1 Projects — Team Managed vs Company Managed

Jira has two types of projects, and this distinction matters enormously for administrators. The project type determines the scope of its configuration — whether settings apply only to that project or are shared globally.

Aspect	Team Managed Project	Company Managed Project
Configuration scope	Project-scoped — settings live inside this project only	Global — shared entities used across multiple projects
Who can configure	Project admin (no global admin needed)	Global Jira administrator only
Work types	Created per-project, not reusable elsewhere	Global work types shared across projects
Workflows	Basic — not customizable via workflow designer	Full workflow designer with statuses and transitions
Boards per project	One board only	Multiple boards per project allowed
Screens/Fields	Simplified field management	Full screen scheme and field configuration control
Best for	Small teams, quick setup, minimal admin	Enterprise, complex workflows, multi-team setups

⚠ NOTE: Everything in a team managed project lives in that project only — work types, fields, automations. In a company managed project, these are global entities shared via schemes. This is the most important architectural distinction in Jira.

2.2 Work Items (Issues) — Structure and Fields

A work item is the fundamental unit of work in Jira. Every piece of trackable work — a bug, a story, a task, an epic — is a work item. Work items have fields that store information about them. Understanding fields is critical because everything in Jira (reports, dashboards, boards, filters) is driven by field values.

Required Fields

- **Summary** — The title/one-line description of the work item. The only mandatory field when creating.

Key Optional Fields

- **Description** — Detailed information about the work item.
- **Assignee** — Who is responsible for this work item.
- **Reporter** — Who created or reported this work item.

- **Priority** — Urgency level — Blocker, Critical, Major, Minor, Trivial.
- **Labels** — Free-form tags for categorization.
- **Story Points** — Agile estimation unit for scrum teams.
- **Due Date** — Deadline for the work item.
- **Sprint** — Which sprint this work item belongs to.
- **Component** — Sub-area of the project this work belongs to.
- **Fix Version/Release** — Which product version this work is associated with.

⚠ NOTE: Fields you hide in the create screen are hidden only for your user account. Hiding fields in project settings affects all users of that project. These are two separate actions.

2.3 Statuses and Status Categories

Every work item has a status that represents where it is in its lifecycle. Jira has three status categories that never change, but you can create as many custom statuses within those categories as you need.

Category	Color	Meaning	Example Statuses
To Do	Gray	Work not yet started	Open, To Do, Backlog, New
In Progress	Blue	Work actively being done	In Progress, In Review, In QA, Needs Approval, Blocked
Done	Green	Work completed	Done, Closed, Released, Won't Do

⚠ NOTE: You CANNOT create custom status categories. You can only create custom statuses and then assign each to one of the three built-in categories (To Do / In Progress / Done). This affects how reports like the Control Chart work — they track time in the 'In Progress' category regardless of the status name.

2.4 Workflows — Statuses + Transitions

A workflow is the defined path a work item can travel — the allowed statuses and the transitions between them. Think of it like a flowchart: each box is a status, each arrow is a transition. Workflows enforce business process rules — for example, a work item might only be able to move to 'In QA' from 'In Progress', not directly from 'To Do'.

Key Workflow Concepts

- **Status** — A state a work item can be in.
- **Transition** — A named arrow between two statuses. The button users click to move work forward.
- **Global Transition** — A transition that allows moving to a status from ANY other status — not just one specific predecessor.

- **Condition** — A rule that must be true for a transition to be available (e.g. only certain user roles can use it).
- **Validator** — A check performed before a transition executes (e.g. a required field must be filled).
- **Post-Function** — An action that runs automatically after a transition (e.g. assign to a specific user).
- **Transition Screen** — A form shown to the user when they trigger a transition — used to capture extra info (e.g. resolution).

⚠ NOTE: Workflow schemes link a workflow to a project. Work type screen schemes link specific screens to specific work types within a workflow. You cannot directly edit an active workflow — Jira creates a draft. Always build new workflows while inactive and only associate them with a scheme when finished.

2.5 Filters and JQL (Jira Query Language)

Filters are saved search queries. Everything in Jira that displays a list of work items — boards, dashboards, the backlog, reports — is powered by a filter under the hood. JQL is the language used to write these filters. Understanding JQL is one of the most valuable skills for power users and administrators.

JQL Syntax

```
field  operator  value

project = WDT
assignee = currentUser()
status = "In Progress"
priority IN (Blocker, Critical)
created >= -7d
due <= endOfWeek()
summary ~ "login"
labels = frontend
sprint in openSprints()
resolution IS EMPTY
```

Common JQL Fields

Field	Description	Example
project	Filter by project key or name	project = WDT
assignee	Who is assigned	assignee = currentUser()
reporter	Who reported it	reporter = john.doe
status	Current status	status = "In Progress"
priority	Priority level	priority IN (Blocker, Critical)
issuetype	Work type	issuetype = Bug
sprint	Which sprint	sprint in openSprints()

Field	Description	Example
created	Creation date	created >= -7d
updated	Last updated date	updated >= -1d
due	Due date	due <= endOfWeek()
labels	Label tags	labels = frontend
component	Component name	component = "API Layer"
fixVersion	Release version	fixVersion = "v2.0"
resolution	Resolution value	resolution IS EMPTY
summary	Title text search	summary ~ "login bug"

Common JQL Operators

- **=** — Equals exactly
- **!=** — Does not equal
- **IN (...)** — Matches any value in the list
- **NOT IN (...)** — Matches none of the values in the list
- **IS EMPTY / IS NOT EMPTY** — Field has no value / has a value
- **~** — Contains text (fuzzy search on text fields)
- **>= / <=** — Greater or less than (for dates and numbers)
- **AND / OR / NOT** — Logical combinators
- **ORDER BY field ASC/DESC** — Sort the results

⚠ NOTE: Basic search and advanced (JQL) search are two views of the same underlying query. Switching from basic to advanced shows you the JQL being generated. You can edit it directly in JQL mode to write queries that basic search cannot express.

Phase 2 — Summary Reference

Concept	Key Point
Team managed project	Self-contained. Project admin configures it. Work types/fields scoped to project only.
Company managed project	Global entities. Needs global admin. Workflows, screens, fields are shared via schemes.
Work item summary	The ONLY required field when creating a work item.
Status categories	Only 3: To Do (gray), In Progress (blue), Done (green). Cannot add more.
Custom statuses	You can create these — but must map each to one of the 3 categories.
Workflow	Statuses + transitions. Cannot directly edit an active workflow.

Concept	Key Point
JQL	Jira Query Language. Powers boards, dashboards, and reports via filters.
Global transition	A transition accessible from any status — not just one specific predecessor.

PHASE 3 — JIRA FOR USERS

3.1 Interface Overview

The Jira interface is divided into two main areas: the top navigation bar and the left sidebar. Everything you need to navigate Jira as a regular user is accessible from these two areas. What you see in the settings menu is tied directly to your permissions — a global admin sees far more than a regular user.

Top Navigation Bar

- **App Switcher** — Switch between Atlassian apps (Jira, Confluence, etc.) — terminology is changing from 'products' to 'apps'.
- **Create Button** — Create a new work item from anywhere in Jira.
- **Notifications Bell** — Alerts when someone @mentions you, assigns work, or comments on your items.
- **Help Icon** — Access Atlassian's documentation — use this for anything not covered in your training.
- **Settings Gear** — Settings visible here are tied to your permission level.
- **Personal Settings** — Profile picture, password, dark mode toggle, and home page configuration.

Sidebar Features

- **For You / Your Work** — Your personal landing page — work assigned to you, recently updated, starred items.
- **Recent** — Quick access to recently viewed projects, boards, and work items.
- **Starred** — Jira's bookmark/favorites system. Star any project, filter, or dashboard for quick access.
- **Projects** — List of all projects you have access to. Browse and search.
- **Filters** — All saved JQL filters. Star favorites. Share with team.
- **Dashboards** — Visual reporting pages made of gadgets/widgets.
- **Teams** — Internal team landing pages (not Microsoft Teams).
- **Plans** — High-level cross-project planning (may require additional license).
- **Apps** — Atlassian Marketplace paid add-ons that extend Jira's capabilities.

⚠ NOTE: The sidebar can be customized — you can hide, show, and reorder items. The default layout is consistent for this course but yours can be cleaned up to remove items your team doesn't use.

3.2 Project Navigation and Views

Inside any project, Jira offers multiple ways to view the same work items. Each view shows the same data but presents it differently to serve different workflows. Understanding all views makes you a much more effective Jira user.

View	Best Used For
Board	Visual kanban/scrum board. See work item cards moving through columns.
Backlog	Sprint planning. Drag work items into sprints. Manage the queue.
List View	Spreadsheet-style. Great for bulk editing, sorting, exporting.
Calendar View	See work items with due dates on a calendar. Visualize deadlines.
Timeline View	Gantt-style. See epics and child issues across time. Set start/end dates.
Summary View	High-level dashboard — status overview, priority breakdown, team workload, epic progress.
Forms	Create public or internal intake forms that generate work items automatically.
Goals	Track high-level objectives and link projects/work items to them.

⚠ NOTE: The board view and the backlog view are separate. The board shows only what is in the current sprint (Scrum) or all work (Kanban). The backlog shows everything not yet in a sprint. You need the backlog to plan sprints.

3.3 Working with Work Items

Creating and managing work items is the core daily activity in Jira. Here is a complete reference for everything you can do with a work item.

Creating a Work Item

- Click the 'Create' button from anywhere or use the keyboard shortcut 'C'.
- Select the project and work type.
- Fill in the summary (required). All other fields are optional.
- You can hide fields you don't need — they are hidden for your account only.

Inside a Work Item

- **Comments** — Collaborate with teammates. Use @mentions to notify someone.
- **Attachments** — Upload screenshots, documents, or any relevant files.
- **Linked Issues** — Link this work item to related, blocked, blocking, or duplicate items.
- **History / Audit Log** — See every field change ever made on this work item — timestamp and who changed it.
- **Watchers** — Users watching a work item get notified of all changes.
- **Subtasks / Child Issues** — Break a work item down into smaller child items.
- **Clone** — Duplicate a work item and all its fields to avoid recreating from scratch.

Breadcrumb Tips (New Feature)

Jira has added powerful shortcuts to the breadcrumb at the top of a work item. These are features many users miss entirely:

- **Epic breadcrumb** — Click or hover on the epic name in the breadcrumb to change or unlink the parent epic instantly — without opening the full edit form.
- **Issue type breadcrumb** — Click the issue type icon in the breadcrumb to change the work type on the fly — a feature that used to require a complex transition process.

⚠ NOTE: These breadcrumb shortcuts are recent additions and are not obvious — you won't know they exist until you try clicking on them. They save significant time in day-to-day work.

3.4 Dashboards

Dashboards are customizable reporting pages made of gadgets (widgets). They let you create a personalized view of your most important Jira information without needing to navigate around. You can build personal dashboards and share them with your team.

Key Dashboard Gadgets

- **Assigned to Me** — A quick list of all work items currently assigned to the logged-in user.
- **Activity Stream** — A live feed of activity across projects — comments, transitions, field changes.
- **Filter Results** — Display any saved JQL filter as a list — essentially a custom report.
- **Pie Chart** — Visualize the distribution of a field (e.g. status, priority, work type) across a filter.
- **Two Dimensional Filter Statistics** — Cross-tabulate two fields — e.g. status vs assignee, priority vs work type.
- **Sprint Burndown** — Track sprint progress over time — how much work remains vs the ideal trajectory.
- **Velocity Chart** — How much work (in story points or hours) was completed per sprint over time.

⚠ NOTE: Boards are powered by saved filters. When you create a new board from an existing project, Jira automatically creates and saves a filter for it. You can edit that filter to control exactly which work items appear on your board.

Phase 3 — Summary Reference

Feature	Key Point
Top nav settings gear	What you see is tied to your permissions. Regular users see very little.
Starred items	Jira's bookmarks. Star any project, filter, or dashboard for quick sidebar access.
Board vs Backlog	Board shows current sprint work. Backlog manages the full queue and sprint planning.
List view	Best for bulk editing, sorting, column configuration, and export.
Timeline view	Gantt-chart style. Set dates on epics and child issues.

Feature	Key Point
Project summary view	Pre-built charts: status, priority, workload, epic progress. Filter by assignee.
Breadcrumb shortcuts	Click epic name or issue type icon in breadcrumb to edit quickly.
JQL filter	Every board, dashboard gadget, and report is powered by a JQL filter.

PHASE 4 — JIRA FOR MANAGERS AND TEAM LEADERS

In this phase, we operate as a project administrator — someone with elevated permissions over a specific project, but not global admin access. The permissions in this phase are additive to everything in Phase 3.

4.1 Teams Feature

Jira's Teams feature is an internal landing page for a group of users. It is NOT Microsoft Teams. Think of it as an intranet page — visible to your colleagues inside the Jira installation, but not publicly facing. It gives the rest of the organization a quick way to see what a team does, who is on it, and what they are working on.

What Teams Contain

- **Header image** — Custom banner image to brand the team page.
- **About section** — Description of the team — written for other users in the organization.
- **Members** — Users added to the team. Their work activity automatically appears.
- **Linked Projects** — Projects this team is working on — linked for quick access.
- **Linked Confluence spaces** — Documentation linked from the team page (requires Confluence license).
- **Help links** — Contact links, request forms, or knowledge articles for the rest of the org.
- **Kudos** — A recognition feature — give public positive feedback to team members.
- **Activity feed** — Auto-populated from the work items assigned to team members.
- **Goals** — Goals the team is contributing to automatically show here.

⚠ NOTE: Teams are independent from project membership. A user can be on a team without being a member of a specific project, and vice versa. This gives you more flexibility to organize your people separately from how you organize your work.

4.2 Creating and Configuring Agile Boards

As a project admin, you can create new boards and configure existing ones. Boards are the primary way teams interact with their work day to day.

Creating a Board

- **From a new project** — Jira creates a board automatically based on the project template (Scrum or Kanban).
- **From an existing project** — Create a new board that pulls work from an existing project via a saved filter.
- **Multi-project board** — Edit the board's filter to pull work items from multiple projects onto one board.

⚠ NOTE: When you create a board from an existing project, Jira auto-creates a saved filter for that board. The board only shows what the filter returns — editing the filter changes what appears on the board without touching the underlying data.

Board Configuration Settings

- **Columns** — Add, rename, remove columns. Map statuses to columns. Reorder columns.
- **Quick Filters** — Custom one-click filter buttons above the board — e.g. 'My Work', 'Bugs Only'.
- **Card Layout** — Configure which fields (beyond summary) appear on card faces — e.g. priority, assignee, labels.
- **Days in Column** — Show how long a card has been in its current column — useful for spotting blockers.
- **Color Coding** — Color cards by priority, assignee, or other fields for visual distinction.
- **Saved Filter** — The JQL query powering this board. Edit it to change which work items appear.

4.3 Running Sprints — Full Workflow

Here is the complete sprint lifecycle as performed inside Jira, from creation to completion.

Creating and Starting a Sprint

```
BACKLOG VIEW → Create Sprint button
  → Name the sprint (e.g. Sprint 14)
  → Add sprint goal (description — tip: include available hours)
  → Set sprint dates (start date, end date)
  → Drag work items from backlog into sprint
  → Or use S+T shortcut to send item to top, then drag down to sprint
  → Select multiple items: Ctrl+Click / Cmd+Click / Shift+Click / Checkboxes
  → START SPRINT when ready
```

During an Active Sprint

- The board shows the active sprint's work items.
- Users move cards across columns as work progresses.
- New urgent items added mid-sprint trigger a notification — move something out to compensate.

Completing a Sprint

- Click 'Complete Sprint' in the active sprint view.
- Jira prompts you: what to do with incomplete items.
- Move to next sprint, move to backlog, or close them.

⚠ NOTE: Keyboard shortcuts in the backlog: S+T sends a work item to the TOP of the backlog. S+B sends it to the BOTTOM. Use these during sprint planning to quickly organize what each person should work on next.

4.4 Customizing Team Managed Projects

Project admins of team managed projects can customize their project without needing global admin access. Here are all the configuration areas available:

Project Navigation Customization

- **Rename tabs** — Change the display names of board, backlog, timeline, etc.
- **Hide/show tabs** — Remove tabs your team doesn't use to reduce clutter.
- **Reorder tabs** — Drag and drop to change the sidebar order.
- **Set default tab** — Choose which view opens first when entering the project (only some tabs support this).

⚠ NOTE: Customizing the project navigation affects ALL users of that project. Hiding a field on a work item affects only your own account. These are different.

Work Types

- **Add suggested types** — Jira offers common work types (Bug, Story, etc.) as quick adds.
- **Create custom types** — Name it, choose an icon, and add it to the project.
- **Custom icons** — Upload your own icon file or choose from presets.

Custom Fields

- **Field types available** — Text, Number, Date, Dropdown / Single Choice List, Multi-Select, User Picker.
- **Add field to work type** — Fields are per work type in team managed projects.
- **Make a field required** — Toggle in field settings — prompts users on create.
- **Set a default value** — Pre-populate a dropdown field for new work items.
- **Reorder fields** — Click and drag fields to reorder them on the create/edit screen.

⚠ NOTE: Changes to fields and work types in team managed projects do NOT save automatically. Always click Save before leaving the settings page.

Features Toggle

Under Project Settings → Features, you can toggle on/off entire sections. This is how Jira sets up the project based on the template you chose (e.g. Kanban template disables sprints and backlog by default):

- **Backlog** — Toggle on to get a backlog view in a Kanban project.
- **Sprints** — Toggle on to enable sprint functionality in a Kanban project (effectively converting it to Scrum).
- **Summary** — Toggle to show/hide the Summary project tab.
- **Timeline** — Toggle to show/hide the Timeline/Gantt view.
- **Goals** — Toggle to enable goal-linking in the project.

Notification Settings

- **Who gets notified** — Configure events: work item created, updated, assigned, commented, transitioned.
- **Custom project email address** — Set a unique from-address so team members can filter emails by project.
- **Project email audit** — View notification delivery errors — useful for troubleshooting missing emails.
- **Slack/Teams integration** — Hook in Slack or Microsoft Teams for in-app notifications.

4.5 Forms Feature

Forms let you create a structured intake form that external or internal users can fill out, which then automatically creates a work item in Jira. This is powerful for collecting feature requests, bug reports, or customer feedback without giving people access to your Jira board.

Creating a Form

- Navigate to Project → Forms → Create Form.
- The work types available in the form are determined by the project it's created in.
- Add fields: the 'Summary' field description becomes the work item summary when created.
- Mark fields as required or optional.
- Reorder fields by dragging.

Making a Form Public

- Click the lock icon → change access to 'Anyone with the link'.
- Assign a reporter — Jira requires every work item to have a reporter, even from public submissions.
- Copy the link and share externally.
- Submissions appear in the project backlog with the assigned reporter.

⚠ NOTE: Every work item in Jira must have a reporter. When making a form public, you must designate a Jira user to be set as the reporter for all submissions made through that form.

4.6 Reporting

Jira has several built-in reports accessible via the project navigation. These are especially valuable for managers monitoring team health and sprint performance.

Report	What It Shows
Burndown Chart	How much work remains in the current sprint vs the ideal burndown line. Tells you if you'll finish on time.
Velocity Chart	How much work (story points/hours) was completed per sprint. Helps forecast future sprint capacity.

Report	What It Shows
Control Chart	How long work items spent in each 'In Progress' status category. Identifies process bottlenecks.
Cumulative Flow Diagram	How work items are distributed across statuses over time. Reveals WIP accumulation and flow problems.

Phase 4 — Summary Reference

Concept	Key Point
Teams feature	Internal landing page for a group of users. Not Microsoft Teams. Intranet-style.
Board filter	Every board is powered by a saved JQL filter. Edit it to control what appears.
Multi-project board	Edit the board's filter to pull work items from multiple projects.
S+T / S+B shortcuts	Send work item to top or bottom of backlog during sprint planning.
Features toggle	Kanban template disables sprints/backlog by default. Toggle on to enable.
Forms reporter	Public forms require a designated Jira user as reporter for all submissions.
Project nav changes	Affect ALL project users. Work item field hiding is personal only.
Burndown chart	Shows remaining work vs ideal sprint trajectory.
Velocity chart	Shows how much was completed per sprint — used for capacity forecasting.

PHASE 5 — JIRA FOR ADMINISTRATORS (Global Admin)

In this phase, we operate as a global Jira administrator — the highest permission level. Global admins configure the shared entities and schemes that all projects and users depend on. Everything here is additive to the knowledge from Phases 1-4.

5.1 Global Admin vs Project Admin

Responsibility	Global Admin	Project Admin
Create projects	Yes (company managed)	Yes (team managed only)
Configure workflows	Yes	No (team managed: basic only)
Create/edit screens	Yes	No
Manage global fields	Yes	No (only project-scoped fields in TMP)
Manage user accounts	Yes	No
Configure permission schemes	Yes	No
Create work types (global)	Yes	No (TMP: project-scoped work types)
Automation	Yes (global scope)	Yes (project scope only)

5.2 Workflows — Full Admin Reference

Workflows are one of the most powerful — and most complex — parts of Jira. As a global admin, you design, build, and maintain the workflows that govern how work moves through your organization.

Building a Workflow

```
Settings → Work Items → Workflows → Create Workflow
  1. Add statuses (from global status list or create new)
  2. Draw transitions between statuses
  3. Configure each transition:
     - Name the transition (this is what users click)
     - Add conditions (who can use this transition)
     - Add validators (what must be true before it runs)
     - Add post-functions (what happens automatically after)
     - Optionally add a transition screen (capture extra info)
  4. Keep workflow INACTIVE until fully built
  5. Associate with a Workflow Scheme
  6. Associate the Workflow Scheme with a Project
```

Workflow Error — No Outgoing Transition

One of the most common admin errors: you add a status to an active workflow, but because the workflow is active (being used by a project), Jira creates a draft. If the new status has no outgoing transition yet, Jira will block you.

⚠ NOTE: Always build workflows while INACTIVE. Only associate a workflow with a workflow scheme (and thus a project) after all statuses and transitions are fully configured. If editing an active workflow, add a global transition first, then refine later.

Workflow Scheme

A workflow scheme maps specific work types to specific workflows. This means Story work items might follow one workflow while Bug work items follow a different one — all within the same project. A project then has one workflow scheme associated with it.

5.3 Screens and Screen Schemes

A screen is the form that appears when a user creates, edits, or views a work item. Different operations on different work types can show different screens — giving you fine-grained control over what information is captured.

Entity	Purpose
Screen	The actual form — a list of fields displayed to the user
Screen Scheme	Maps a screen to an operation (Create, Edit, View)
Issue Type Screen Scheme	Maps specific screen schemes to specific work types within a project

The Chain

Project → Issue Type Screen Scheme → Screen Scheme → Screen → Fields

This chain means: for this project, when this work type is being created, show this screen, which contains these fields.

⚠ NOTE: When you create a custom field and want it to appear on the create form, you must: 1) Create the field, 2) Add the field to the correct Screen, 3) If you only want it on one work type, create a new Screen Scheme and associate it with that work type via the Issue Type Screen Scheme.

5.4 Fields and Field Configurations

Custom fields extend Jira's data model to capture information specific to your team's needs. Field configurations control how fields behave — required vs optional, visible vs hidden.

Available Field Types

- **Text Field (single line)** — Free text. Use sparingly — misspellings break filters.
- **Text Area (multi-line)** — For longer free-form descriptions.
- **Number** — For quantities, scores, or numeric tracking.
- **Date / Date Time** — Date pickers for scheduling.
- **Single Choice List** — User picks one option from a dropdown. Best for categorical data.

- **Multi-Select List** — User picks multiple options.
- **User Picker** — Reference a Jira user — useful for tracking approvers, reviewers.
- **Checkbox** — Boolean yes/no field.

⚠ NOTE: Always choose the most appropriate field type, not just a text field. Single-choice dropdowns prevent misspellings and inconsistent values, making JQL filtering much more reliable.

Field Configuration

A field configuration controls per-field behavior. You can set each field to:

- **Required** — Users must fill this in to save the work item.
- **Optional (default)** — Users may fill this in but don't have to.
- **Hidden** — Field exists but is not shown on the screen.

Field Configuration Scheme

A field configuration scheme maps field configurations to specific work types in a project. By default, one field configuration applies to all work types. To make a field required only for one work type, you need a separate field configuration scheme.

5.5 Components

Components are sub-categories within a project that help organize work items. Think of them as tags that indicate which area of the product or process a work item belongs to. Unlike labels, components are structured and per-project.

Key Component Facts

- **Scope** — Components are per-project — you cannot use a component from one project in another.
- **Component lead** — Each component can have its own lead user, allowing granular auto-assignment.
- **Default assignee** — A component can set its own default assignee independently of the project default.
- **Work item association** — A work item can be tagged with one or more components.
- **Filtering** — Filter by component in JQL: component = 'API Layer'.
- **Reports** — Dashboards can filter by component to show component-specific metrics.

Components + Automation Example

One powerful use case: set up an automation rule that fires when the Component field changes to 'AV Production', and then automatically reassigns the work item to the AV team lead. This chain (component → automation → reassignment) removes manual routing work from the team.

```
Trigger: Field Value Changed → field = Component
Condition: Work Item Field Condition → Component = 'AV Production'
Action: Edit Work Item → Assignee = Noah
```

⚠ NOTE: Setting a component lead does NOT automatically assign work items to them. The lead is a reference point. Use automation rules if you want automatic assignment when a component is applied.

5.6 Versions (Releases)

Versions (also called Releases in parts of the Jira interface) group work items together by product release. They answer the question: 'What was in version 2.0?' — what bugs were fixed, what features were added, what tasks were completed for that release.

Version Status	Meaning
Unreleased	Work is still in progress toward this version.
Released	This version has been shipped/deployed.
Archived	Old version, no longer actively tracked.

Working with Versions

- **Create a version** — Go to Project Settings → Versions → Create Version. Give it a name and release date.
- **Associate a work item** — Open a work item, set the Fix Version field to the appropriate version.
- **View version contents** — Click a version to see all associated work items.
- **Filter by status category** — Within a version, filter by To Do / In Progress / Done to see what's left.
- **Release a version** — Click 'Release' to mark it as shipped. Optionally move unfinished items to the next version.
- **Release notes** — Can be linked to Confluence pages or design tools like Figma.

⚠ NOTE: 'Version' and 'Release' are used interchangeably in Jira's interface. You will see both terms referring to the same feature — this is a Jira terminology inconsistency that has persisted across updates.

5.7 Resolutions

Resolutions capture how or why a work item was moved to Done. Not all 'Done' items are the same — some were completed properly, some were duplicates, some were deferred, some are things the team decided not to do. Resolutions give you a way to distinguish between these outcomes and filter on them later.

Default Resolutions in Jira

- **Done** — Work was completed as intended.

- **Won't Do** — A conscious decision was made not to complete this work.
- **Duplicate** — This is a duplicate of another work item.
- **Cannot Reproduce** — A bug that cannot be replicated.

Creating a Custom Resolution

```
Settings → Work Items → Resolutions → Add Resolution
  → Name it (e.g. 'Deferred', 'Backlogged for Later', 'Moved to Product')
  → This resolution now appears as an option on transition screens
```

The resolution is applied via a transition screen — when a user drags a work item to Done, a screen pops up asking them to select the resolution. This ensures the reason for closure is always captured.

⚠ NOTE: Filtering by resolution = EMPTY finds all work items moved to Done that had no resolution explicitly set. This is how you can identify items that may have been closed prematurely.

5.8 Automation

Automation in Jira follows an 'If This Then That' model. You define a trigger, optionally add conditions to narrow when the rule fires, and then define actions to take. Automation removes repetitive manual work — auto-assigning, auto-transitioning, auto-notifying.

Automation Rule Structure

Part	Options
Trigger	Field value changed, Work item created, Work item transitioned, Scheduled, Incoming webhook
Condition	Work item field condition, JQL condition, User condition, Comparison condition
Action	Edit work item, Transition work item, Assign work item, Send notification, Create sub-task, Send Slack/Teams message

Example Rules

```
Rule 1: Auto-assign by component
Trigger: Field Value Changed → Component
Condition: Component = 'AV Production'
Action: Edit Work Item → Assignee = Noah

Rule 2: Auto-transition on all subtasks done
Trigger: Work Item Updated → all sub-tasks done
Action: Transition parent → Done

Rule 3: Notify on high priority creation
Trigger: Work Item Created
Condition: Priority = Blocker
Action: Send notification to Project Lead
```

⚠ NOTE: Automation scope differs: in team managed projects, automation applies only to that project. In company managed projects, automation can be scoped to a project or globally across all projects. Global automation requires global admin permissions.

Phase 5 — Summary Reference

Concept	Key Point
Workflow build order	Build inactive → add statuses → add transitions → configure rules → activate → associate with scheme.
Workflow draft	Editing an active workflow creates a draft. Inactive workflows can be edited directly.
Screen chain	Project → Issue Type Screen Scheme → Screen Scheme → Screen → Fields
Field type advice	Use dropdowns/lists over text fields wherever possible to enable reliable JQL filtering.
Components scope	Per-project only. Component lead does NOT auto-assign — use automation for that.
Versions	'Version' and 'Release' are the same feature. Status: unreleased / released / archived.
Resolutions	Why work was closed. Applied via transition screens. Filter: resolution IS EMPTY finds uncategorized Done items.
Automation scope	Team managed = project only. Company managed = can be global.

PHASE 6 — INTERVIEW FAVOURITES AND ADVANCED CONCEPTS

6.1 Common Interview Questions and Strong Answers

Q: What is the difference between a team managed project and a company managed project?

A team managed project is self-contained — its work types, fields, and automation are scoped to that project only. It can be configured by a project admin without needing global admin access. A company managed project uses global entities — workflows, screens, fields, and permission schemes — that are shared across projects via schemes. Company managed projects require a global Jira administrator to configure and offer much more flexibility and control, making them suitable for enterprise setups.

Q: What are the three status categories in Jira and why do they matter?

The three are To Do, In Progress, and Done. These cannot be changed or extended. They matter because Jira's built-in reports — especially the Control Chart — use these categories internally. For example, the Control Chart measures how long a work item spends in the In Progress category, not in a specific named status. This means you can have 10 different statuses all mapped to In Progress, and Jira will track them all together for cycle time purposes.

Q: What is a workflow scheme and how does it connect to a project?

A workflow scheme is a mapping between work types and workflows. For example, Story issues might follow Workflow A (with a code review step), while Bug issues follow Workflow B (with a QA step). The workflow scheme is then associated with a project, so the project inherits those mappings. The chain is: Project → Workflow Scheme → (Work Type → Workflow → Statuses + Transitions).

Q: Why can't you directly edit an active workflow?

Because the workflow is already being used by a live project with active work items. Jira protects you from making changes that could put existing work items into invalid states. Instead, Jira creates a draft of the workflow that you can edit. When you publish the draft, it replaces the live version. If you need to add a new status to an active workflow, add a global transition first (so the new status is reachable from anywhere), then refine the transitions later on the draft.

Q: What is JQL and write a query to find all high-priority bugs assigned to you in the current sprint?

JQL is Jira Query Language — the structured query language used to search and filter work items across Jira. Here is the query:

```
project = WDT
AND issuetype = Bug
AND priority IN (Blocker, Critical, High)
AND assignee = currentUser()
AND sprint in openSprints()
```

```
ORDER BY priority DESC
```

Q: What are components and how are they different from labels?

Components are structured sub-categories of a project — they must be defined by an admin and are specific to a single project. They can have component leads and interact with automation. Labels are free-form tags that any user can add, and they are not per-project. Components give you structured, controlled categorization; labels give you flexible ad-hoc tagging.

Q: What is the purpose of resolutions in Jira?

Resolutions capture the reason or outcome when a work item moves to Done. Not all Done items are the same — some were completed, some were duplicates, some were deferred. A resolution allows you to filter later using JQL (resolution = 'Won't Do') to find all the work that was consciously not completed. Resolutions are applied via transition screens that appear when users move work to Done.

Q: How does a board know which work items to show?

Every Jira board is powered by a saved JQL filter. When you create a board, Jira auto-creates a filter for it. That filter defines exactly which work items appear. By editing the filter, you can pull work from multiple projects, filter by specific work types, or apply any JQL condition. The board is just a visual presentation layer on top of that filter — it does not affect the underlying data.

6.2 Key Distinctions to Know Cold

Confused Pair	The Real Distinction
Jira Teams vs Microsoft Teams	Jira Teams = internal landing page for a user group. No relation to Microsoft Teams the communication tool.
Status vs Status Category	Statuses are custom names (Open, In QA, etc.). Categories are the 3 fixed buckets they map to.
Component Lead vs Auto-Assign	Setting a component lead does NOT auto-assign. Use an automation rule for that.
Versions vs Components	Versions group work by release timeline. Components group work by product area. Both are per-project.
Team Managed vs Company Managed	TMP: project-scoped entities, project admin. CMP: global entities via schemes, global admin.
Project admin vs Global admin	Project admin controls one project. Global admin controls all projects and global configurations.
Form Summary field vs Work Item Summary	The 'summary' label in a form is a description for users. The actual work item summary is created from the form's description field content.
Hiding fields (personal) vs Project nav	Hiding fields on a work item = personal (your account). Hiding project nav tabs = affects all project users.

Confused Pair	The Real Distinction
Version / Release	Same feature. 'Release' is legacy terminology. Both terms appear in the Jira interface.
Issues vs Work Items	Same thing. 'Issues' is the legacy term. 'Work items' is the current term. Both appear in the interface.

6.3 Admin Configuration Chain — Complete Reference

When a work item is created in a company managed project, the following configuration chain determines what it looks like and how it behaves. Know this chain — it is the backbone of Jira admin work.

```
Work Item Lifecycle Chain:
  Project
  └─ Workflow Scheme
     └─ (Work Type → Workflow)
           └─ Statuses + Transitions + Conditions + Post-Functions

  Project
  └─ Issue Type Screen Scheme
     └─ (Work Type → Screen Scheme)
           └─ (Operation → Screen)
                 └─ Fields

  Project
  └─ Permission Scheme
     └─ (Permission → Role or Group)

  Project
  └─ Field Configuration Scheme
     └─ (Work Type → Field Configuration)
           └─ (Field → Required / Optional / Hidden)
```

⚠ NOTE: If something is not showing up in a project, work backward through this chain. Wrong screen? Check the Issue Type Screen Scheme. Wrong workflow? Check the Workflow Scheme. Missing permission? Check the Permission Scheme.

6.4 Quick Reference — JQL Functions

JQL Function	What It Returns
currentUser()	The currently logged-in user
openSprints()	All sprints that are currently active
closedSprints()	All sprints that have been completed
futureSprints()	Sprints that have been created but not started
now()	The current date and time
startOfDay()	Midnight of today

JQL Function	What It Returns
endOfDay()	End of today
startOfWeek()	Start of the current week
endOfWeek()	End of the current week
startOfMonth()	First day of the current month
endOfMonth()	Last day of the current month
-7d / -1w	Relative date: 7 days ago / 1 week ago

6.5 Scenario Questions

Scenario: A user says their Jira notifications are going to spam. What do you check?

Go to Project Settings → Notifications → Email settings. Check if a custom project email address is configured. If the from-address looks unfamiliar, email clients often flag it as spam. Consider changing it to a recognizable domain address. Also check the project email audit for any delivery errors. Finally, ask the user to add the from-address to their trusted senders list.

Scenario: A manager wants to see only bugs assigned to their team across three projects on one board.

Create a new board (Kanban works well for cross-project views). When prompted for a filter, write a JQL query: project IN (PROJ1, PROJ2, PROJ3) AND issuetype = Bug AND assignee IN (membersOf('customer-service-team')). Save this as the board's filter. The board will now show only bugs from those three projects assigned to team members.

Scenario: A work item was dragged to Done but the work was never actually completed. How do you track this?

Create a custom resolution such as 'Deferred' or 'Not Yet Done'. Configure the Done transition in the workflow to show a transition screen with the Resolution field on it. Now when users drag to Done, they are prompted to select a resolution. Later, use JQL to find these: resolution = 'Deferred' AND status = Done. This is the pattern the instructor described for their real consulting client.

Scenario: The team wants new feature requests from external users to automatically appear in the backlog.

Create a form in the relevant project. Add the appropriate fields. Set the form to Public (anyone with the link). Designate a Jira user as the reporter. Share the form link externally. Every submission will create a work item in the project backlog with the designated reporter. You can then filter by reporter to quickly find and triage all external submissions.

Overall Interview Takeaway

Jira is a highly configurable agile work management tool. Its power comes from its layered configuration model — entities like workflows, screens, fields, and permission schemes are defined globally and applied to projects via scheme associations. Understanding this architecture — and being able to trace a problem back through the configuration chain — is what separates a strong Jira admin from someone who only knows how to create a ticket.

If asked about...	Lead with...
Jira overview	Agile work tracking tool by Atlassian. Assumes agile methodology. Two project types: team managed vs company managed.
Scrum vs Kanban	Scrum has sprints (time-boxed). Kanban is continuous flow. Both use daily standup. Both available as board types in Jira.
Workflow	Statuses + transitions. Three status categories (fixed). Workflow schemes link workflows to projects. Build inactive, then activate.
JQL	Jira Query Language. Powers all boards, dashboards, filters, and reports. Key operators: =, IN, IS EMPTY, ~, AND/OR.
Admin chain	Project → Scheme → Configuration entity. Work backward through this to troubleshoot any configuration problem.
Components vs Labels	Components: structured, admin-defined, per-project. Labels: free-form, user-defined, any project.
Resolutions	Why a work item was closed. Applied via transition screens. Filtered later with JQL.